

Chapter 2: Why China's Bureaucratic System Was So Formidable Amidst the Wave of Feudalization

The reflections of the previous stage, while solving a considerable number of problems, also brought about some new ones. Intuition tells me that the known results and the unknown questions are all parts of a larger truth. However, before seeing the full picture, I cannot determine the interrelationships between these parts. Therefore, the best choice is presumably to tackle the easy before the hard. I decided to first attempt to answer what is, for me, the simplest question: namely, why, even though China was not the only one to experience the period of **classical empires** (古典帝国时期), the **Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise** (地主-官僚妥协) ultimately only caused a reversal of the **feudalization** (封建化) process in China?

In my preliminary explorations in early October, I had already provided two explanations:

First, the area and population of Northern China were far too massive, and the difficulty of governing a state cannot possibly scale linearly with the growth of population and area. Using ten times the number of *barbarians* (蛮族) to control ten times the area and ten times the number of conquered people is obviously not as simple as when none of these three figures are multiplied by ten.

This forms a highly distinct contrast with the situation of the Western Roman Empire. Although the population and territory of the Western Empire were also astonishing, we can easily notice that in reality, various branches of *barbarians* entering the Roman territory each controlled a specific portion of the Western Empire. This is vastly different from the Xianbei rulers facing the entirety of Northern China in the 5th century CE; consequently, the pressure they experienced was absolutely incomparable.

Second, unlike the Eastern Roman Empire, which had to divert massive energy into confronting Persia and the Arabs, the Five Dynasties of Jiangzuo (江左五朝) faced no threats from their rear, thus allowing them to strategically direct their full force northward.

The distribution of ethnicities, cultures, and religions within its borders was also far more homogeneous than in the Eastern Empire. The Han people still held absolute dominance in the South. Therefore, if we assume that the reunification of North and South did not occur at the end of the 6th century but persisted for much longer, there is actually considerable reason to believe that the Jiangzuo regimes could have maintained the image of "half of the Chinese Empire" for quite a long time. They would not have increasingly become an empire of the Greeks like the Eastern Empire, nor would they have developed a "Southern Orthodox School" of Confucianism. (*This is a joking expression, as the Orthodox Church of Byzantium ultimately split from the Catholic Church in Rome and became increasingly characterized by Greek traits.*)

Thus, the Southern Dynasties regimes would bring far greater military and political pressure upon the northern ethnic minority rulers. These two factors undoubtedly made the northern minority rulers more resistant to implementing **feudalization** policies in the north through heavy-handed measures, making them more inclined to reach a compromise with the Han landlords.

But if one were to believe that this is sufficient, they would lose the scientific spirit of seeking truth. Some well-known histories of our country demonstrate that although the "**Landlord-Bureaucrat**

Compromise" (地主—官僚妥协) concentratedly manifested during the eras when ethnic minorities dominated the Central Plains, its embryonic form emerged much earlier.

A highly representative piece of evidence is that Emperor Wen of Wei, Cao Pi (魏文帝曹丕), having just received the Mandate of Heaven from the Han, adopted the proposal of the Prefect of the Masters of Writing, Chen Qun (尚书令陈群), to establish and implement the Nine-Rank System (*Jiupin Zhongzheng Zhi* / 九品中正制). Although this system underwent several transformations and cannot be equated across different historical periods, it nevertheless profoundly influenced China for several centuries, only exiting the historical stage when the imperial examination (*Keju*) system gradually matured.

Facing the overarching historical trend since the Eastern Han Dynasty—the rise of powerful magnates evolving into elite lineages (门阀), and the resurgence of feudal relations within the empire—the Nine-Rank System indeed proposed the first internal solution for the empire. It was a solution that attempted to incorporate the increasingly powerful **feudal landlords** (封建地主) into the *bureaucratic system* (官僚体制) by granting them a procedural pathway to control state power.

The prolonged chaos since the end of the Jin Dynasty completely fails to obscure the success of this scheme. Even during the Eastern Jin—the era when the aristocratic clans reached their absolute zenith—the emerging landlord class could always find a point of equilibrium within the bureaucratic system and cautiously coexist with imperial power.

The issue worth noting is that when Cao Pi implemented the Nine-Rank System in Northern China, although the migration of ethnic minorities into *Handi* (China Proper / 汉地) had already been underway for a long time, it was still nearly a century away from the massive invasion by the *barbarians* (蛮族).

This implies that, setting aside one party to the compromise—namely, the ethnic minorities entering the Central Plains—China's original *bureaucratic system* itself had already demonstrated far stronger adaptability and resilience than the bureaucratic systems of the rest of the **classical empires** (古典帝国) in the world. In other words, before the ethnic minorities conquered Northern China, China's bureaucratic system was already exceptionally formidable.

It is precisely this realization that demands we trace further back into history, to examine exactly what exceptional circumstances occurred when the imperial system was initially established. As briefly mentioned before, the unification by the Qin Dynasty was simply too brief and unpopular, so much so that its influence has consistently been vastly overestimated. Therefore, the focus of our observation is placed on the era when the Chinese Empire was truly forged: the Western Han Empire.

So, regarding its bureaucratic system, what distinguished China's classical empire during the Western Han period from other **classical empires**? In reality, apart from Rome, we can currently hardly know with certainty the exact modes of political operation of these classical states. For Persia, India, and the Khmer, their political systems must largely be deduced through fragmentary records.

Under such conditions, the exceptional nature of the Western Han system becomes particularly glaring. Not only did it possess a massive number of bureaucrats appointed top-down, but most astonishingly, in an era before the Common Era, China already possessed a nationwide official

selection system—namely, the *Chaju* (察举 / recommendation) and *Zhengbi* (征辟 / conscription) systems. This system was guided by an official ideology recognized by the entire society, possessed relatively clear regulations and operational procedures, and was strictly controlled by the court.

This set of systems for selecting, promoting, demoting, appointing, and dismissing officials clearly distinguished Han China from other **classical empires**. The Han bureaucratic system possessed a certain capacity for self-replenishment and self-repair, without the need to rely entirely on the emperor's intervention.

We can imagine that in classical states lacking such a system, who served as regional governors or court chancellors depended more on where the emperor wished to dispatch his cronies, rather than on a systematized procedure. Undoubtedly, this very characteristic of the Han bureaucratic system was the source of its strength and resilience when the wave of **feudalization** arrived.

This system was not established in a single day. It ultimately finalized only after over a century of prolonged development during the Western Han Dynasty. The monarch who played the greatest role in this was undoubtedly Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝). So, what exact factors catalyzed this transformation?

I believe the critical factors are twofold. First, the sudden outbreak of high-intensity natural disasters during Emperor Wu's reign; and second, the staggering scale of the counterattack-expansion wars. It was precisely because the Han Empire was forced to simultaneously tackle these two severe challenges, both internally and externally, that the necessity arose to elevate state capacity to a level considered extremely anomalous for that era. The personal aptitude of Liu Che (刘彻 / Emperor Wu) made this possible.

前一个阶段的思考在解决了相当多问题的时候又带来了一些新的问题，直觉告诉我，现在已知的结果和未知的问题都是一个更大真相的一部分。但是在见到全貌之前我没办法确定这些部分之间相互的关系，所以最好的选择想必是先易后难，我决定先去试着回答对我来说最为简单的问题，也就是为什么尽管不只有中国经历了古典帝国时期，但是官僚地主妥协最终只在中国使得封建化进程出现了逆转。在十月初的初步探索中我已经给出了两个解释：第一，北中国的面积和人口太过庞大，而治理国家的难度不可能随着人口和面积的增长呈线性，用十倍数量的蛮族去控制十倍面积和十倍数量的被征服者，显然不可能跟这三个数量都不乘十的时候一样简单。这与西罗马帝国的情况产生了非常明显的对比，尽管西帝国的人口和疆域也十分惊人，但我们很容易注意到实际上是进入罗马疆域的各支蛮族分别控制了西帝国的某一部分，这与鲜卑统治者在公元五世纪面对整个北中国是不一样的，因而感受到的压力不可同日而语。第二，与东罗马帝国不得不将大量精力放到与波斯和阿拉伯的对抗中不同，江左五朝并不存在背后的威胁，因而在战略上可以全力面向北方。其境内的民族、文化和宗教分布也比东帝国要单一许多，汉人在南方依然占据着绝对的优势，因此如果我们假定南北统一没有在六世纪末发生而是又持续了很久，那么事实上有相当理由认为江左政权还能在相当长的时间中保持“半个中华帝国”的形象，而不是如东帝国那样越来越成为希腊人的帝国，或是发展出“南方正统学派”的儒学。（这是一种开玩笑的说法，因为拜占庭的东正教会最终与罗马的天主教廷分裂了，并且越来越具有希腊特征）如此，南朝政权将会给北方少数民族统治者带来更大的军事上的和政治上的压力。这两个因素无疑都会使北方少数民族统治者更加抗拒用强势的手段在北方推行封建化政策而倾向于与汉族地主达成媾和。

但是如果仅仅认为这样就足矣，那便失去了求真的科学精神，因为我们国家的一些众所周知的历史表明，“地主—官僚妥协”尽管集中表现在少数民族入主中原的年代，但是其萌芽却要更早。极有代表性的证据便是魏文帝曹丕刚刚从汉处接过天命便采纳尚书令陈群的建议制定并推行了九品中正制，这一制度虽然说几经流变，在不同历史时期不可等量齐观，但是毕竟深刻影响了中国数百年，直到科举制度逐渐完善才退出历史舞台。面对东汉以来豪强士族崛起并向门阀演变，封建关系在帝国境内抬头的历史

大势，九品中正制的确在帝国内部首先提出了解决的一个方案，一个通过给予越来越强大的封建地主掌控国家权力的流程来试图将其纳入官僚体制内部的方案。晋末以来的长期混乱完全无法掩盖这一方案的成功之处，即使是在东晋这一门阀最为鼎盛的年代，新兴地主阶级也总是能在官僚体制内寻求一个平衡点，并且谨慎地与皇权共存。而值得注意的问题在于，当曹丕在中国北方推行九品中正制的时候，尽管少数民族向汉地的迁移已经开始了很久，但是距离蛮族大规模入侵尚有将近一个世纪。这就意味着抛开妥协的其中一方，也就是进入中原的少数民族不谈，中国原本的官僚体制本身已经就比世界上其余的那些古典帝国的官僚体制展现出了更强的适应性和韧性，换句话说，在少数民族征服北中国之前中国的官僚体制就已经太过强大了。正是这一认识要求我们必须向历史的更早处进行回溯，去看看帝国体制最初建立的时候究竟发生了什么样的特殊情况。之前已经简单说过，秦朝的统一实在是太过短暂并且不得人心，以至于其影响一直以来都被大大高估了。因此观察的重点就放到了中华帝国真正肇造的年代，也就是西汉帝国。

那么西汉时期中国的古典帝国就其官僚制度而言与其他古典帝国有什么区别呢？实际上除了罗马以外，现在我们几乎无法确切地知道这些古典国家的政治运作方式，对于波斯，印度和高棉来说，其政治体制更多是要通过零散的记载进行推断。也就是在这种条件下，西汉体制的特殊性就变得尤为明显，其不但拥有自上而下任命的庞大官僚数量，最为令人称奇的是，在公元前这样的年代中国就拥有了一套由受到全社会认可的官方意识形态指导的，有相对清晰规章和运作流程的，受到朝廷控制的，面向全国范围的选官制度，也就是察举制（和征辟）。这一套遴选和决定官员升黜任免的制度将汉代中国与其他古典帝国明显地相区分，汉代的官僚体制有一定自我补充和修复的能力，而不需要完全依赖于皇帝的干预。我们可以想象在没有这样一种体制的古典国家，地方的总督，朝堂上的宰相由谁担任更多是看皇帝愿意将自己的亲信派往哪里，而缺少一套制度化的流程。毫无疑问，汉代官僚制度的这一特征就是当封建化浪潮到来的时候其强度和韧性的来源。这个制度不是一天建立起来的，而是历经了西汉一个多世纪的漫长发展才最终定型，其中起到最大作用的君王毫无疑问是汉武帝，那么究竟是什么因素促成了这种变化？我认为关键性的因素是两点，其一是汉武帝统治时期骤发性的高烈度自然灾害，其二是规模惊人的反击-扩张战争，正是因为汉帝国不得不在内外同时应付这两个严峻挑战，所以才产生了将国家能力提升到一个在当年看来极为反常的程度，刘彻本人的才干使这一点成为可能。